PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #80 · SUBSTANCE ABUSE

“I can’t be myself around people unless I use first.”

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Where it often comes from

Some people use because being with others feels impossible without a buffer. The room is too bright, the words will not come, or the real self feels like too much or not enough. “I can’t be myself unless I use first.” That can be social fear, old shame, or a habit that now feels like personality. You are not faking a self when you are sober. You are meeting people without a screen. It can be awkward and still be you. God already knows you without it. Safe people can learn to know you too, in small doses, with help. If you want help, call the SAMHSA National Helpline at 1-800-662-4357. Do not try to stop or withdraw on your own if that could make you sick. A doctor can help you do it safely, and a counselor can walk with you. Needing that help is not a failure.

What Scripture teaches

You can approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that you may receive mercy and find grace to help. You do not have to chemically prepare yourself to come to God, and you do not have to be impressive to come to people. You are fearfully and wonderfully made. Grace is sufficient in weakness, including the weakness of feeling unlike yourself in a room. Jesus sets people free. He is near the brokenhearted. These verses do not demand that you become outgoing. They say the self God made does not require using in order to be real.

> *“Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need”* (Hebrews 4:16).

Also see

> “I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well” (Psalm 139:14).

> “But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me” (2 Corinthians 12:9).

> “So if the Son sets you free, you will be free indeed” (John 8:36).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

Common self-statements

- Nobody wants the sober version of me.
- I am boring, or too much, unless I use.
- I cannot talk to people without it.
- If I do not use first, they will see the real me and leave.
- This is just my personality.
- God is disappointed by the self I am in a quiet room.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling the buffered self the real you and the other self a failure.
- Mind reading: Deciding people will reject you before they have met you without it.
- Fortune telling: Deciding every social hour without using will be unbearable.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling unlike yourself and concluding you are not yourself.

Challenging questions

- Who told me, or what taught me, that I am not acceptable as I am?
- What is one person and one short visit I could try without using first?
- Is the fear of being seen the same as being unlovable?
- What does God already know about me that I am trying to hide?
- What would "a little at a time" look like, with a counselor's help?
- If withdrawal or a sudden stop would make me sick, what should I ask a doctor before I experiment?

Truth summary

> I can be myself without using first. God already knows me, and I can practice being with safe people a little at a time.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

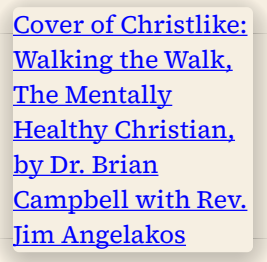
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Friendship
- Fear
- Love, By God
- Help

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love
- Anxiety/Worry/Fear

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



Cover of Christlike: Walking the Walk, The Mentally Healthy Christian, by Dr. Brian Campbell with Rev. Jim Angelakos

From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

You Say — Lauren Daigle
What God says about you is enough for you to be in the room.

Clean — Natalie Grant
You do not have to arrive altered in order to be received.

Speak O Lord — Keith and Kristyn Getty
God's Word can give you a self to stand in, a little at a time.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
Christ is gentle with the person who is afraid to be seen without a buffer.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can't be myself around people unless I use first."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can't be myself around people unless I use first." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who told me, or what taught me, that I am not acceptable as I am?
- ☐ What is one person and one short visit I could try without using first?
- ☐ Is the fear of being seen the same as being unlovable?
- ☐ What does God already know about me that I am trying to hide?
- ☐ What would "a little at a time" look like, with a counselor's help?
- ☐ If withdrawal or a sudden stop would make me sick, what should I ask a doctor before I experiment?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I can be myself without using first. God already knows me, and I can practice being with safe people a little at a time.
- ☐ Needing a buffer is understandable. It is not my identity.
- ☐ The person I am without it is still me.
- ☐ God receives me without my having to prepare a different self.
- ☐ I can start with one safe person and a short time.
- ☐ Awkward is not the same as fake.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Hebrews 4:16
  "Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need."
- ☐ Psalm 139:14
  "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9
  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When you used in order to be yourself: Each day, write down one moment when you felt you could not be with people unless you used first. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Hebrews 4:16 becomes: "James can write: "I can come as I am and find grace to help. I do not have to use first to be real.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. For help with substance use, call 1-800-662-4357, and talk with a doctor before you stop if withdrawal could make you sick.

- [ ] Plan one short time with a safe person without using first. Tell your counselor the plan. Keep it small.
- [ ] If that is not medically safe yet, do not force it. Ask a doctor how to approach days without using.
- [ ] Call 1-800-662-4357 if you need help finding that doctor or a counselor.
- [ ] Pray Hebrews 4:16 before the next room you are afraid to enter as yourself.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can't be myself around people unless I use first.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment I showed up without using first
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can't be myself around people unless I use first~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have believed I cannot be myself unless I use first. You already know me. Give me grace to be seen, a safe person, and a doctor's help so I do not do this in a dangerous way. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.